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Prarambik

In India, every art form has its own significant position. Song, music, dance, sculpture, painting, and many such forms of art have traditions dating back centuries.

The 14 branches of knowledge and 64 forms of art are the foundation of Indian culture. Hence, studying these arts is considered equal to praying or meditation.

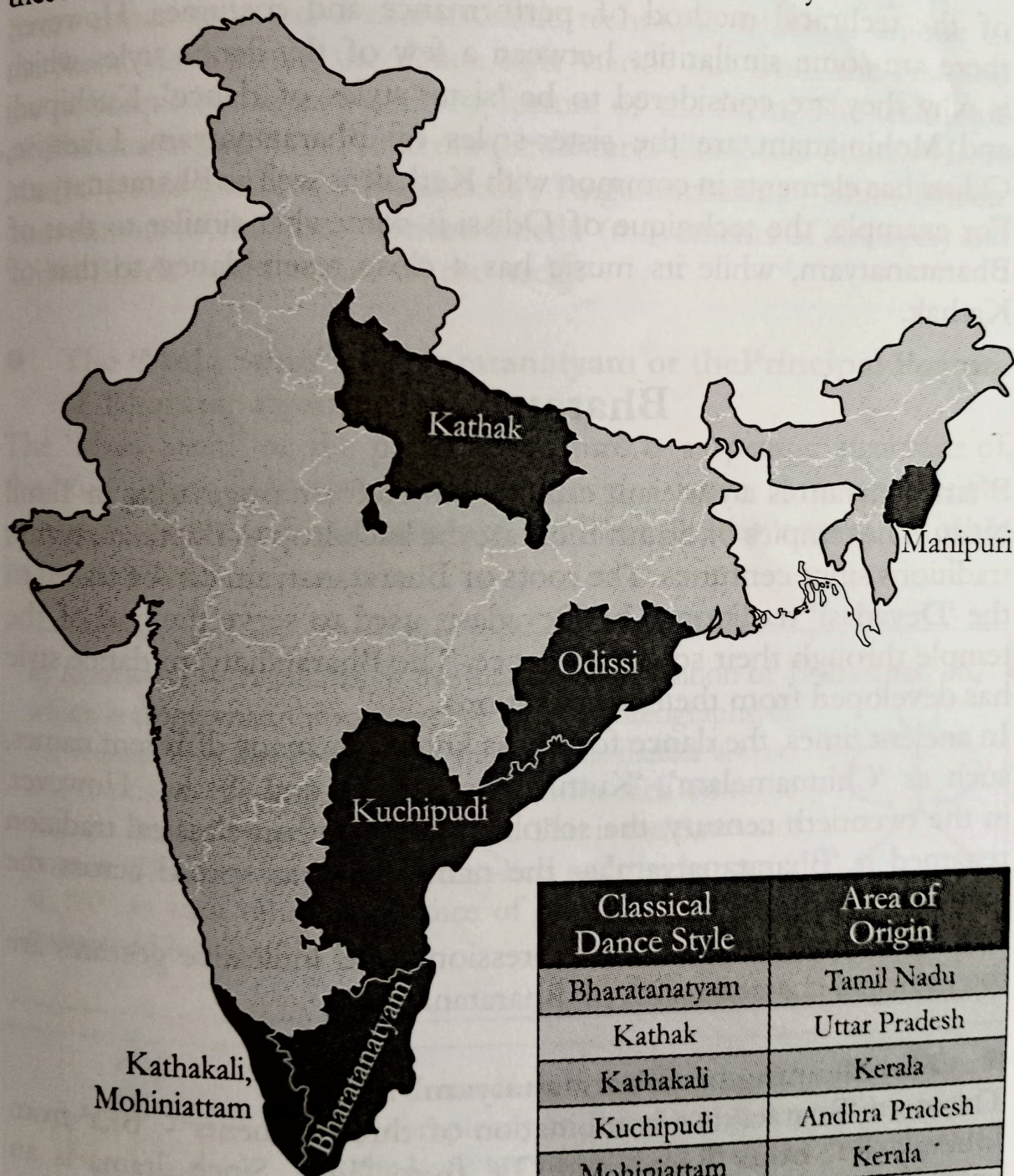
Of these, dance is one of the oldest art forms. For thousands of years, people have followed the tradition of dance in different regions of India.

These folk dances are an integral part of festivals, joyous occasions and weddings. In ancient times, dance was performed as a part of the daily rituals in various temples. Religious rites and celebrations in the temples also saw the inclusion of dance performances.

Classical dance was thus born in India through these different regional dances. Nevertheless, these dances can all be traced to a common classical root, i.e., Bharatamuni's 'Natyashastra'. Over the years, regional dance styles adopted a number of elements from their respective areas of origin. The rules, traditions, and culture of the regions became the distinguishing factors and led to the formation of the seven principal classical dance styles.

● Classical Dance Styles of India

There are seven main classical dance styles prevalent in India. All of these have originated in different regions of the country.



Classical Dance Style	Area of Origin
Bharatanatyam	Tamil Nadu
Kathak	Uttar Pradesh
Kathakali	Kerala
Kuchipudi	Andhra Pradesh
Mohiniattam	Kerala
Odissi	Odisha
Manipuri	Manipur

In addition to these, the 'Satriya' dance style of Assam has also recently become popular throughout India.

The seven classical dance styles are different from each other in terms of the technical method of performance and costumes. However, there are some similarities between a few of the dance styles which is why they are considered to be 'sister-styles of dance'. Kuchipudi and Mohiniattam are the sister-styles of Bharatanatyam. Likewise, Odissi has elements in common with Kathak as well as Bharatanatyam. For example, the technique of Odissi is somewhat similar to that of Bharatanatyam, while its music has a close resemblance to that of Kathak.

Bharatanatyam

Bharatanatyam is an ancient classical dance form originating in Tamil Nadu. The temples of South India are the backdrop to Bharatanatyam's traditions since centuries. The roots of Bharatanatyam can be traced to the 'Devadasi' tradition. The Devadasis used to serve the god of the temple through their song and dance. The Bharatanatyam dance style has developed from their compositions.

In ancient times, the dance form was known by many different names, such as 'Chinamelam', 'Kuttu', 'Dasiattam', and 'Sadir'. However, in the twentieth century, the scholars of the Indian classical tradition renamed it 'Bharatanatyam' – the name that has spread across the world today.

Rhythmic movements, vivid expressions, and indicative gestures are the principal characteristics of Bharatanatyam.

● The Meaning of 'Bharatanatyam'

The word 'Bharata' is a combination of three elements – 'Bha' from 'Bhava', 'Ra' from 'Raga', and 'Ta' from 'Tala'. Since drama is an important part of dance, the word 'Natyam' was also included. Together, they formed the word 'Bharatanatyam', i.e., the dance form that is a unique combination of 'Bhava' (emotion), 'Raga' (music), 'Tala'

(rhythm) and 'Natya' (expression).

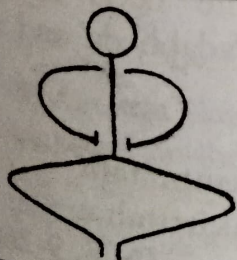
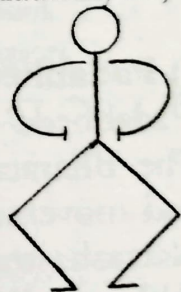
Principal Elements of the Technique of Bharatanatyam

Every dance style has a characteristic technique which is unique to the form. As a result, the dance style stands out from the rest and the technique becomes a defining feature of the form. The technique of Bharatanatyam has several unique features like 'Mula Sthiti', 'Hasta Mudra' (hand gestures), 'Padabheda', 'Angasanchalana', 'Shiro Bheda' (movements of the head) 'Drishti Bheda' (movements of the eyes) and 'Griva Bheda' (movements of the neck).

● The 'Mula Sthiti' of Bharatanatyam or the Principal Posture of Bharatanatyam

The 'Mula Sthiti' or the principal posture is a specific structure of the body which is consistent throughout the dance. 'Aramandi' is the principal posture in Bharatanatyam. Additionally, there are a few other postures as well.

a) Aramandi – 'Aramandi' is the fundamental position of Bharatanatyam, which is maintained throughout the entire choreography of the sequence. In this posture, the spine of the dancer is erect and the knees are bent outward, away from each other, so that the dancer is in a half-sitting state. This is the Aramandi posture. The feet are placed heel-to-heel and the knees are at 180° to each other. A distance of about 2-3 inches is maintained between the feet.



b) Murumandi – When the dancer folds his/her knees completely in the Aramandi position, such that the heels are raised away from the ground, it is called 'Murumandi'. In this position, the dancer has to maintain his/her balance on the strength of the toes and the outstretched knees.